RAMBAM'S INTRODUCTION TO HELEK: OLAM HABA & THE 13 PRINCIPLES

First Before All, Worship Him Alone: Principles 4 & 5

Rambam's Introduction to Helek, Part 11

Source: The Rambam's Introduction to Perek Helek: Principle 4 (*Kadmut*) and Principle 5 (worship of Hashem alone)

Shiur: Part 11 of the series on the Rambam's Introduction to Perek Helek, given by Dayan Daniel Kada on Zoom, Tuesday 16 December 2025 (third night of Chanukah; the last shiur of the term)

These notes are based on the transcript of the recording.

Recap

Principles 1–3: **a First Cause**; **one**, in the refined sense; **no body**, no physical attributes or emotions, **the only principle with no explicit source** in Torah or Chazal. Tonight, **4 and 5**, completing **the five about Hashem**. *(Remember: the Rambam wrote this in his twenties; the Moreh came decades later.)*

Part 1: Principle 4: Two Texts

The common text

היסוד הרביעי: הקדמות. והוא שנאמין כי זה האחד האמור הוא קדמון בהחלט, וכל נמצא זולתו הוא בלתי קדמון בערכו אליו. והראיות על זה בכתבי הקודש רבות. והיסוד הרביעי הזה מורה עליו מה שנאמר: מענה אלהי קדם.

He alone is absolutely prior; everything else, however ancient, **is not**, relative to Him. **מענה אלהי קדם**: from the Torah's last parashah, "**which we say on Simchat Torah**."

On this text, Principle 4 is only: Hashem precedes all else.

Rav Shilat's text

The same, then an **addition**:

ודע כי היסוד היותר גדול שבתורת משה רבנו הוא היות העולם מחודש, המציאו הקב״ה ובראו אחר ההעדר הגמור. וזה שתראני סובב סביב ענין קדמות העולם על דעת הפילוסופים, הוא כדי שיהיה המופת על מציאותו יתעלה מוחלט, כמו שבארתי במורה.

The greatest foundation of Moshe's Torah is that the world is newly made: Hashem brought it into being after complete nothingness. When I seem to entertain the philosophers' **eternity of the world**, it's only to prove **His existence** absolutely, **as I explained in the Moreh**.

"As I explained in the Moreh": written **decades later**. **Rav Shilat** says the Rambam **added it when revising**; the **Oxford manuscripts** show his **marginal additions** to the Commentary.

The difference: *"Hashem precedes everything"* vs *"Hashem created from nothing."* "You may think it's the same. **It's not so straightforward.**"

Three views of creation (Moreh 2:13)

	View	The universe	Matter	The Rambam
Torat Moshe	**Ex nihilo**: only God, then the world from **absolute nothing**	**Has a beginning**	**None before**	**"The view of all who believe in the Torah of Moshe"**
Aristotle	God and universe **both eternal**. Creation from nothing is **absurd**; no miracles; nothing changes	**No beginning or end**	Eternal	**Rejects entirely**
Plato	God made the world from **eternal formless matter** (***hyle***, **היולי**), since **even God can't do the impossible**, and something from nothing is impossible	**Has a beginning**	**Coexists eternally with God**, **under His control**	**Sympathetic** (below)

Aristotle "was **very much the scientific view until the Big Bang theory**. **We now know he was completely wrong**, and **the Rambam called him out in the 12th century**." (The Moreh lists **eight proofs** of Aristotle's; "we don't need to go through them.")

Rishonim who held like Plato

Ibn Ezra on **בראשית ברא אלהים**: *most commentators* say **ברא** = **something from nothing** (e.g. Korach: **ואם בריאה יברא ה׳**). **But ויברא... את האדם**, from **earth** (*adamah*)! So **ברא** means **לגזור ולשום גבול נגזר, והמשכיל יבין**: **to shape, to set boundaries**. **Hashem formed the world from pre-existing matter.**

The Ralbag held the same.

The Kuzari: himself **ex nihilo**, but **ואם יצטרך בעל תורה להאמין ולהודות בהיולי קדמון ועולמות רבים קודם העולם הזה, לא היה בזה פגם באמונתו, כי העולם הזה חדש מזמן ידוע מתחלת האדם**. **If a believer feels he must accept eternal matter, even prior worlds, his faith is unblemished**: what matters is that **this world began**.

The Ramban (opening of Bereishit): ***yesh me'ayin*** is **a principle of faith**, possible for an omnipotent God; deny it and **you're a heretic**. **The mainstream of the Rishonim.**

What did the Rambam hold?

Moreh 2:25:

- **Aristotle:** *if his proofs were compelling, I'd reinterpret the Torah. They aren't.* And his view **uproots miracles, and so the whole Torah**.

- **Plato:** **דעת זו אינה הורסת יסודי התורה**: **this view doesn't destroy the Torah's foundations**. It **allows miracles**; **the verses can be read according to it**; some even **support it better**. **But nothing compels us**, so **we read the verses simply: creation from nothing.**

"**The Rambam held ex nihilo, like the Ramban and most Rishonim, no question.** But I read him **like the Kuzari**: Plato's view is **compatible with the Torah**. ***Beseder*, you may.**"

So which text?

Common text: Principle 4 = **Hashem precedes everything**, which **all agree** is fundamental. **Ibn Ezra is within the faith.**

Rav Shilat's text: ex nihilo is **part of the principle**, so **Ibn Ezra would be a *kofer***.

"I find Rav Shilat's text **difficult**": *the greatest foundation of Moshe's Torah* is **creation from nothing**, when in the Moreh he's **sympathetic** to Plato?

Hilchot Teshuvah 3 ("**Rav Shilat doesn't reference this**"): the five kinds of *min*: no God; two gods; a body; ***והאומר שאינו לבדו ראשון וצור לכל***: **"not alone First and Rock of all"**: **just *first***, matching **the common text**. "**Interesting that he doesn't emphasise ex nihilo here.**"

What matters most

There *is* a beginning: now accepted by science; **the world isn't eternal** as Aristotle thought. **Hashem precedes everything.** Possibly also **ex nihilo**: certainly **the correct and majority view, and the Rambam's own**.

Why the Torah begins with *Bereishit. Talmai (Ptolemy) had 72 Sages translate the Torah separately, and miraculously they all made the same changes in several places, lest it be misread. One: they reordered אלהים ברא בראשית to בראשית ברא אלהים*, lest readers think* "Bereishit" *is a god who created* Elohim**. (The Gemara:** darkness descended **that day; "**so many misconceptions come from not reading the original**.")*

"**So why does the Torah open with *Bereishit*?** Because **there *is* a beginning, and so things can change.** Believe like Aristotle and nothing changes: no miracles, no control. **A beginning means Hashem can change the world, and so can we: the world, and ourselves.**"

Ani Ma'amin: שהבורא... הוא ראשון והוא אחרון. "**Last** isn't part of this principle" (eternity belongs to Principle 1). **Yigdal: קדמון לכל דבר אשר נברא, ראשון ואין ראשית לראשיתו**: nothing precedes His being first. **Neither addresses pre-existent matter.**

Robert: *if there's a beginning, must there be an end? Or does matter continue forever?*

"**I need to get back to you on that.** My understanding is **it's possible the world is eternal**, but I need to check the Moreh. **I don't think the two are necessarily dependent.**"

Part 2: Principle 5

היסוד החמישי: שהוא יתברך הוא הראוי לעבדו ולגדלו ולהודיע גדולתו ולעשות מצותיו, ושלא יעשו כזה למי שהוא תחתיו במציאות, מן המלאכים והכוכבים והגלגלים והיסודות ומה שהורכב מהם, לפי שכולם מוטבעים בפעולותיהם, אין להם משפט ולא בחירה אלא לו לבדו יתברך. וכן אין ראוי לעבדם כדי שיהיו אמצעים לקרבם אליו, אלא אליו לבדו יכוונו המחשבות ויניחו כל מה שזולתו. וזה היסוד החמישי הוא שמזהיר מעבודה זרה, ורוב התורה מזהרת עליו.

Three elements

#	
1	**Serve Hashem**: worship, magnify, make His greatness known, keep His mitzvot
2	**Serve nothing below Him**: angels, stars, spheres (which the Rambam, and Rav Saadia, held **have awareness**), the elements, or **what's made from them** (idols). They act **by nature, without judgement or choice**
3	**Not even as intermediaries** to bring us closer to Him. **Direct your thoughts to Him alone**

"Most of the Torah warns against it": from the **Golden Calf** through the prophets and **Baal**.

	Says	Missing
Ani Ma'amin: שהבורא... לו לבדו ראוי להתפלל, ואין לזולתו ראוי להתפלל	Pray only to Him	**Intermediaries** (perhaps implied)
Yigdal: הנו אדון עולם לכל נוצר, יורה גדלתו ומלכותו	He's Master of all creation	"**The vaguest stanza of Yigdal.** Where does it say **don't serve anyone else**? You have to add: *He's Master of all, therefore serve Him only*"

Element 1: why we serve

"**Hashem doesn't need our service.** We don't pray **to change His mind**. **We serve because it's best for us**: **a perfect God needs no worship.**"

Element 3: the Golden Calf

The Ramban: after Sinai they **believed**: they'd seen and heard Hashem. **They wanted something tangible.**

Why Moshe broke the Tablets ("I read this somewhere; I can't remember where"): **not anger**. He saw **they needed something physical**: ***give them the Tablets and they'll worship the Tablets.***

"**This replays in every generation**: always something new to connect to Hashem through. **Because He's so hard to relate to, we want something tangible: strings, blue things on our bodies, everyone has their own. All distractions** from focusing on God **directly**, and distractions are always alluring."

Graves

"**It's incredible how widespread this has become in the *frum world. Every few years, a new grave where you'll see a miracle. The newest, in the last ten years: Reb Shayele of Kerestir. Hardly anyone had heard of him; now ordinary people fly to Romania: go to him and you'll have ***parnassah***. **He wrote no *sefarim*; we have none of his.** He was a great rebbe who **fed the poor**, so *if you go, you'll have food*."

Is visiting graves permitted?

Yes, there's a source. Calev went to **pray at the Avot** in Me'arat HaMachpelah on the spies' mission. **A *tzaddik*'s resting place has significance**, and prayer may be more accepted there.

But nothing is intrinsic. It **inspires** us to connect to Hashem: praying by the Avot, he **thought of Avraham, Yitzchak and Yaakov**, and was moved **to act like them**. "Perhaps **in that person's merit** your prayer is more accepted. **Perhaps.**"

"**But Meron and such places**, if you've been you know: **people pushing each other out of the way to get one metre closer**, to **touch the *tziyun***, as if prayer works better nearer. **For me, that's *avodah zarah*.** A violation of this principle."

Enosh's mistake

Hilchot Avodah Zarah 1: in **Enosh**'s day people reasoned: *Hashem made the stars and spheres to run the world and honoured them, so He wants us to honour them: as you'd show respect to the guards at Buckingham Palace out of honour for the king.* They built **shrines**, offered **sacrifices**: ***avodat kochavim***.

Ch. 2: עיקר הצווי בעבודה זרה שלא לעבוד אחד מכל הברואים, לא מלאך ולא גלגל ולא כוכב... ואף על פי שהעובד יודע שה׳ הוא האלהים והוא עובד הנברא הזה על דרך שעבד אנוש.

Even knowing Hashem is God, serving a creature as Enosh did, as an intermediary, is forbidden.

Summary

1. **Principle 4:** Hashem is **absolutely prior** to everything. **Rav Shilat's text** (a later addition referencing the Moreh) makes **ex nihilo** "the greatest foundation."
2. **Three views: ex nihilo** (Torat Moshe); **Aristotle's eternal universe** (rejected: no miracles; **disproved by the Big Bang**); **Plato's eternal matter** (**Ibn Ezra**, **Ralbag**; the **Kuzari** tolerates it; the **Ramban** calls its holders heretics).
3. **The Rambam held ex nihilo** but found **Plato compatible with the Torah**. On the **common text** (and Hilchot Teshuvah's **"First"**), **Ibn Ezra stays within the faith**.
4. **Bereishit**: **there's a beginning, so change is possible**, for Hashem and for us (and **Talmai's 72 Sages**).
5. **Principle 5:** serve **Hashem alone**, for **our** sake; nothing beneath Him, **not even as an intermediary** (Enosh, the Golden Calf, **the broken Tablets**).
6. **Graves inspire**; **nothing is intrinsic**. **Pushing to touch the *tziyun* is *avodah zarah*.**

Coming Up

After the break, the week of 5 January 2026: Tuesday nights resume with **Principles 6 and 7, prophecy** (the start of the next four, on **revelation**). Monday nights finish **Menachem Meshiv Nefesh** and begin a new *sefer*; Thursday halachah resumes. *(No Thursday shiur this week: the Rabbi has a public lighting.)*

"Chanukah sameach: a beautiful and illuminating Chanukah, good news for Am Yisrael, and a refreshing break."

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